

Episode 122: Once Upon a Time... 70 – 1994 Part 4 – What! A Bus to "Higashikurume Station"!

At last, *The Tatami Galaxy* began last week (Tokyo area). Did everyone get a chance to watch? For me personally, this is my first NoitaminA slot since *Graveyard Kitaro* two years ago, and I'm hoping for the kind of excitement we had with *Graveyard Kitaro*.

Probably readers of this WEB Anime Style who regularly watch anime will watch it, but I especially want people who don't usually watch much anime to see it. *The Tatami Galaxy* is a work I especially want such people to watch. I'd love for office ladies and such to watch it too.

So everyone reading this, please spread word-of-mouth promotion to "general" audiences! Rather than ratings concerns, our feeling focuses on one point: having as many people as possible watch what we're creating.

So this week is Episode 2, "Film Club 'Misogi'." This week too, please support us! Please look forward to it!!

Now then.

March 14, 1994, Manila. Stepping outside the freezingly air-conditioned airport lobby, there was a tremendous number of people's unfamiliar language clamour, deafening car horn floods, and joke-like muggy heat.

"Hmm, foreign country!"

I stood dazed for a while pushing a cart loaded with luggage. Local people gathered around me like that. They seemed to be taxi drivers. Among "Taxi" words mercilessly showered on me was mixed "Shacho-san, Taxi wa?" "!" Mixed with local Tagalog and

English was incredibly suspicious Japanese (laugh). I mean, who's the company president? (laugh)

Then, "Ah, Tsujita-san! Over here!" came a properly solid Japanese voice. It was Soya-san, a locally stationed Japanese staff member who'd come to meet me at the airport, and Palabrica-san from EEI-TOEI staff who'd been in Japan for extended training. After brief reunion greetings, we got in a car and left the heavily congested airport arrival area. "How is it? The Philippines (laugh)" said Soya-san. "How, or rather, what can I say..." I replied. I heard the airport arrival exit is generally always that crowded. In the heavily air-conditioned car interior, my sweat finally subsided.

The car ran through Manila's centre to Quezon City adjacent to Manila City. The EEI-TOEI studio was along West Avenue there. West Avenue felt somewhat removed from downtown bustle, fairly residential. Ah, in Tokyo terms, it's like running through Ginza or Shinjuku and ending up in Nerima's Oizumi (laugh). Even in Manila, anime studios are built in similar places—I was strangely convinced.

The studio was an old single-storeys building. How to put it—somewhat different from a factory, and not modern either. Like a warehouse attached to a larger private house that had been expanded and remodelled onto that house—if I had to say, it gave a "town factory" impression. Right inside the gate was an entrance with one guard uncle carrying a pistol at his waist. When we pulled out the heavy aluminium cases from Tokyo from the car, local staff who came out to meet us carried them in. And I was reunited with Tachisen-san, another Japanese staff member. After handing over souvenirs for both, Palabrica appeared again. "Tsujita-san (←this was in Japanese), Now, we'll go to the hotel."

Hastily into the car again. I was taken to the hotel where I'd stay. The hotel I was taken to was reasonably nice, but ah, Japanese probably won't work here, I thought. Anyway, even the front desk had no Japanese-speaking staff, making me nervous again. I'll probably be at the studio most of the time and just come back to sleep, so it'll be fine! I

half-convinced myself. After being shown to a twin room and putting down luggage, another car ride back to the studio.

On the way to the studio, I kept watching roadside scenes and traffic flow. Shop and building signs everywhere displayed Japanese and American company names and Japanese product advertisements. I'd sort of heard about this, but seeing it firsthand felt strange. If this were Japanese text, wouldn't you momentarily think it was Japan?

Passing cars were mostly Japanese, with occasional Korean or American makes. Jeepneys—shared mini-buses that are the local people's "legs," or rather like covered small trucks—were running around quite a bit. And what really surprised me were the route buses. Japanese route buses were actually running! Not Japanese-made buses—actual Japanese buses. Seibu buses with displays like "To Higashikurume Station" were running as-is.

Perhaps as part of Japan's Southeast Asian aid, used buses that had gotten old in Japan were transported to this country and running actively in current service. Since Japan and the Philippines naturally have opposite traffic lanes, what they'd done was suddenly switch doors and driver seats left-right. Glass on doors that became fixed and couldn't open still had "automatic door" text remaining... This was quite a culture shock for me. Such things weren't much reported or discussed in Japan.

Watching such Manila scenes made me feel strange. The *Dragon Ball* and *Sailor Moon* I'd brought today—Japanese anime gets painted in places like this, created in places like this.

While I was lost in such thoughts, the car arrived at the studio. Now, finally a full studio tour. It would be my first meeting with local staff.

(10.04.27)